during Israel's war of independence, and the house was declared "absentee property". It changed hands a few times, until it was bought by a wealthy Argentinean Jew who transferred it to a yeshiva called Shirat Moshe, which is located near the sea, about a kilometer away. The building on my street was to be used as a residence for dozens of students.

Shirat Moshe was founded in 2008, in an effort to establish a "Jewish presence" in Jaffa. Not that one is lacking: about two-thirds of Jaffa's residents are Jewish. But they tend to be secular and liberal. At my neighborhood polling station, center-left Zionist parties and the Joint List won roughly 80 per cent of the vote in 2015. The yeshiva was, in essence, a national-religious settlement inside Israel's 1948 borders. It has posted flyers warning of the widespread "assimilation" in the community. "20 per cent of children are born to mixed marriages", one leaflet claimed. (A gross exaggeration: Jewish-Arab marriages are exceedingly rare, even in Jaffa.) Eliyahu Mali, the yeshiva's reclusive rabbi, once complained to a religious website that Jaffa was "empty of Jewish content".

Mali also described the Arabs in Jaffa as "resident aliens", rather than full citizens. Many of his students seemed to agree. They routinely heckled my neighbors, calling them "inferior", "dirty Arabs", and other derogatory terms. They called the police throughout that first summer, often on spurious grounds—once because a child kicked a ball into their courtyard. Some of my Arab neighbors have been stopped by police and asked for identification on their own street, where their families have lived for decades. The community organized weekly protests, one of which was joined by Knesset members from Meretz and the Joint List. Eitan Shmueli, who lives with his family in the apartment below me, received a letter from the yeshiva's lawyer, warning him to stop "provoking and inciting" against the dormitory.

It was a small, local story, barely covered in the Israeli press, let alone my own newspapers. Yet it was also deeply revealing. For most of Jaffa's residents, the neighborhood's character is a source of pride and optimism, the rare place in greater Israel that suggests Jews and Arabs are not doomed to internecine conflict. Yet for a growing segment of the Israeli population, that *modus vivendi* is a source of anger and disappointment, one they are actively working to undo. The municipality has offered little help, even though it probably could: the building is zoned as a private residence; using